



PEAK INSIGHT REPORT

Peak 2026

What Peak 2025 tells you to do **now**

Peak 2025 takeaways

Peak 2025 started earlier and ran longer than most shippers plan for.

01

Peak starts in October

- Volume started climbing in late October
- It ran 81% above normal at its peak and stayed high for 4 weeks
- Be ready by late October

02

International peaks later and harder

- International peaked 2 weeks after domestic
- It hit 3.7x a normal week against 1.7x for domestic
- Plan for the week of the 7th of December 2026

03

Multi-carrier holds up under pressure

- Single-carrier shippers had 11% more undelivered parcels
- Set up and test a second courier before November

04

Mondays are the pressure point

- The 4 busiest days were all Mondays
- Cyber Monday ran at 3.1x a normal day
- Staff up and book collections for Mondays

05

No scan means no tracking

- Missing scans were our most common Peak call
- Only label parcels that are ready to go
- Check your label printer before Peak

06

January brings the returns

- Returns peaked in mid-January
- Staff up for mid-January rather than the week after Christmas

A series of thin, light blue wavy lines that sweep across the right side of the slide, creating a sense of motion and depth.

01

Peak Analysis

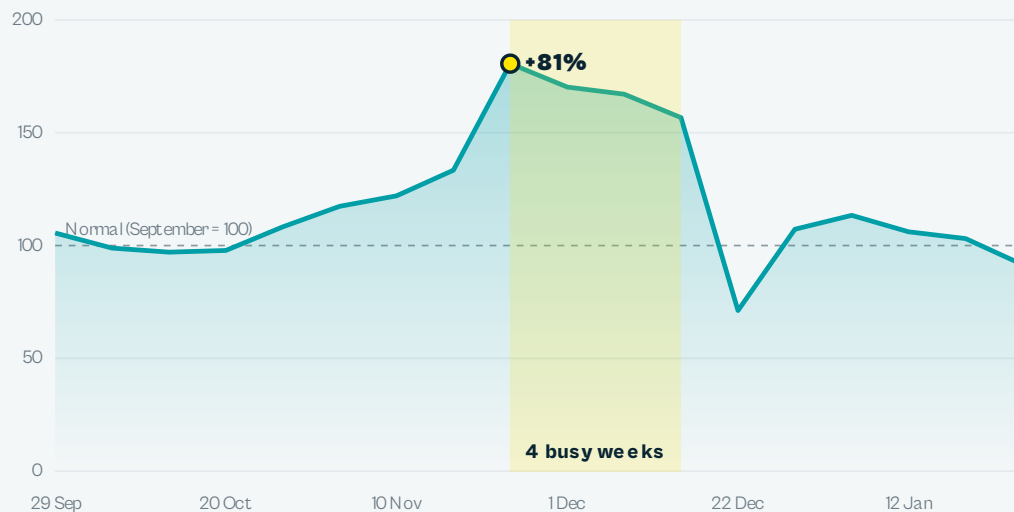
What Peak 2025 told us



Peak started in October, not November

Volume started climbing in late October and stayed well above normal until mid-December.

WEEKLY VOLUME VS NORMAL



+17%

Volume in the week of the 3rd of November, 3 weeks before Black Friday week

+57%

Volume in the week of the 15th of December, 3 weeks after the busiest week

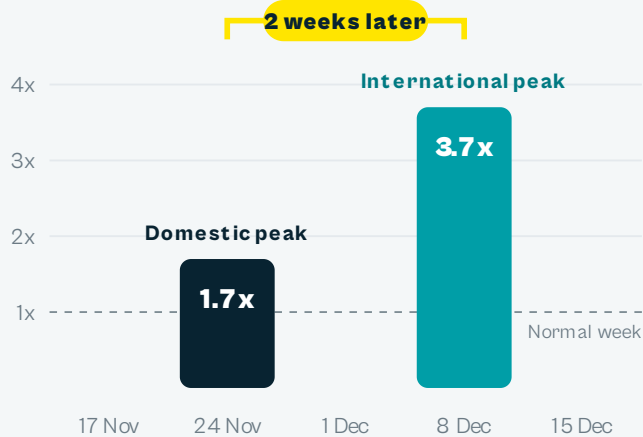
WHAT TO DO NOW

- 1 Have stock, packaging and extra staff in place by **late October**.
- 2 Plan for **4 busy weeks** from late November rather than a Black Friday spike.
- 3 Share your volume forecast with ITD in October so capacity is in place before volume climbs.

Your busiest international week isn't your busiest week

International volume peaked 2 weeks after domestic and more than twice as sharply.

EACH PEAK WEEK COMPARED WITH ITS OWN NORMAL WEEK



+67%

Overall volume above normal in the week international peaked

4.5%

International share of all volume in its peak week, more than double its usual 1.9%



"International doesn't peak when domestic does. It lands in the second week of December. Make sure your main international services and a backup courier are ready by the end of November."

CHARLES CHAIT
SALES DIRECTOR, ITD GLOBAL

WHAT TO DO NOW

1

Plan for the week of the 7th of December, which is likely to be your international peak.

2

Plan for 3.7x a normal week rather than the 1.7x of your domestic curve.

3

Have a second courier live so you can move volume when a network is full.

MULTI-CARRIER VS SINGLE-CARRIER

11%

Shippers relying on a single carrier had **11% more parcels go undelivered** during Peak than shippers with a second carrier ready.

Undelivered means no delivery scan was recorded. Peak 2025, ITD platform data.

Most Peak volume came from multi-carrier shippers

Shippers relying on a single carrier handled less than a fifth of all Peak volume.

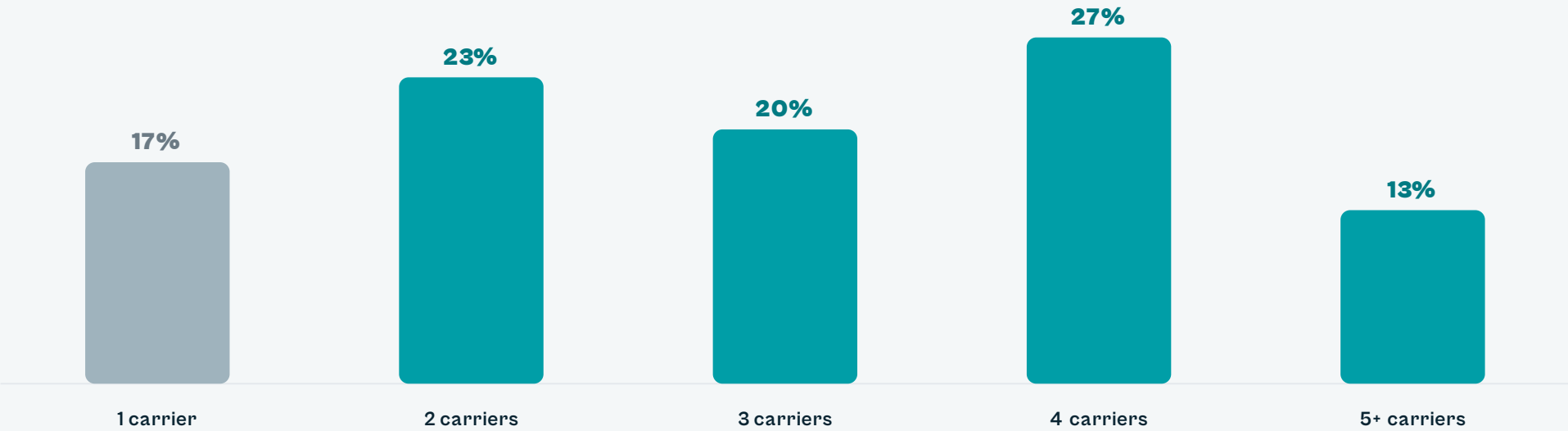
17%

of November-December volume went through a single carrier

83%

of November-December volume went through 2 or more carriers

SHARE OF PEAK VOLUME BY NUMBER OF CARRIERS USED, NOVEMBER-DECEMBER 2025



PRESSURE POINTS

Mondays carried the load

Weekend orders landed on Monday, which made it the busiest day of the week throughout Peak.

DAILY VOLUME VS A NORMAL SEPTEMBER DAY, PEAK 2025

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
w/c 17 Nov				1.4x	1.4x	0.8x	0.9x
w/c 24 Nov	2.4x	1.7x	1.8x	1.8x	2.0x	1.3x	1.6x
w/c 1 Dec	3.1x	2.1x	1.7x	1.6x	1.5x	0.9x	1.1x
w/c 8 Dec	2.6x	2.0x	1.9x	1.7x	1.6x	0.8x	1.1x
w/c 15 Dec	2.5x	2.0x	1.9x	1.7x	1.4x	0.8x	0.7x
w/c 22 Dec	1.6x	0.9x	0.6x				

Below 2.3x normal 2.3x normal or more

3.1x

Cyber Monday compared with a normal September day, and our busiest day ever

+47%

The average Peak Monday compared with the average Tuesday to Friday

WHAT TO DO NOW

1

Make Monday your strongest day.
Roster your most experienced team and book extra collections.

2

Plan for the 30th of November.
Cyber Monday 2026 is likely to be your busiest day of the year.

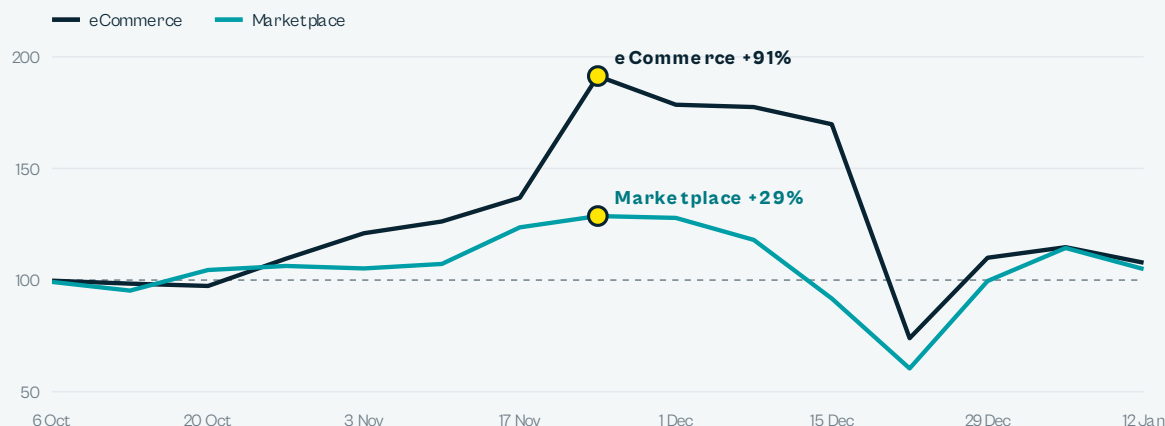
3

Clear the weekend backlog early.
Process weekend orders first thing on Monday so they don't spill into Tuesday.

Different sellers, different peaks

eCommerce stayed busy until mid-December while Marketplace rose less and dropped off sooner.

WEEKLY VOLUME BY SEGMENT, INDEXED (SEPTEMBER = 100)



+91%

eCommerce volume in Black Friday week compared with a normal September week

+29%

Marketplace volume at its peak in the same week, a much smaller lift

12% → 15%

Share of domestic parcels sent next-day or 24-hour, September to December

WHAT TO DO NOW

1

eCommerce: volume stayed 70–91% above normal for 4 weeks. Resource for a month rather than a single weekend.

2

Marketplace sellers: volume fell 8% below normal by the week of the 15th of December. Front-load stock and dispatch into November.

3

Everyone: next-day rose from 12% to 15% of domestic parcels. Have a next-day service live and priced before December.

AFTER CHRISTMAS

January isn't quiet

Outbound volume bounced back after Christmas and returns hit their highest level in mid-January.

RETURNS RAISED THROUGH ITD, DECEMBER TO JANUARY



+19%

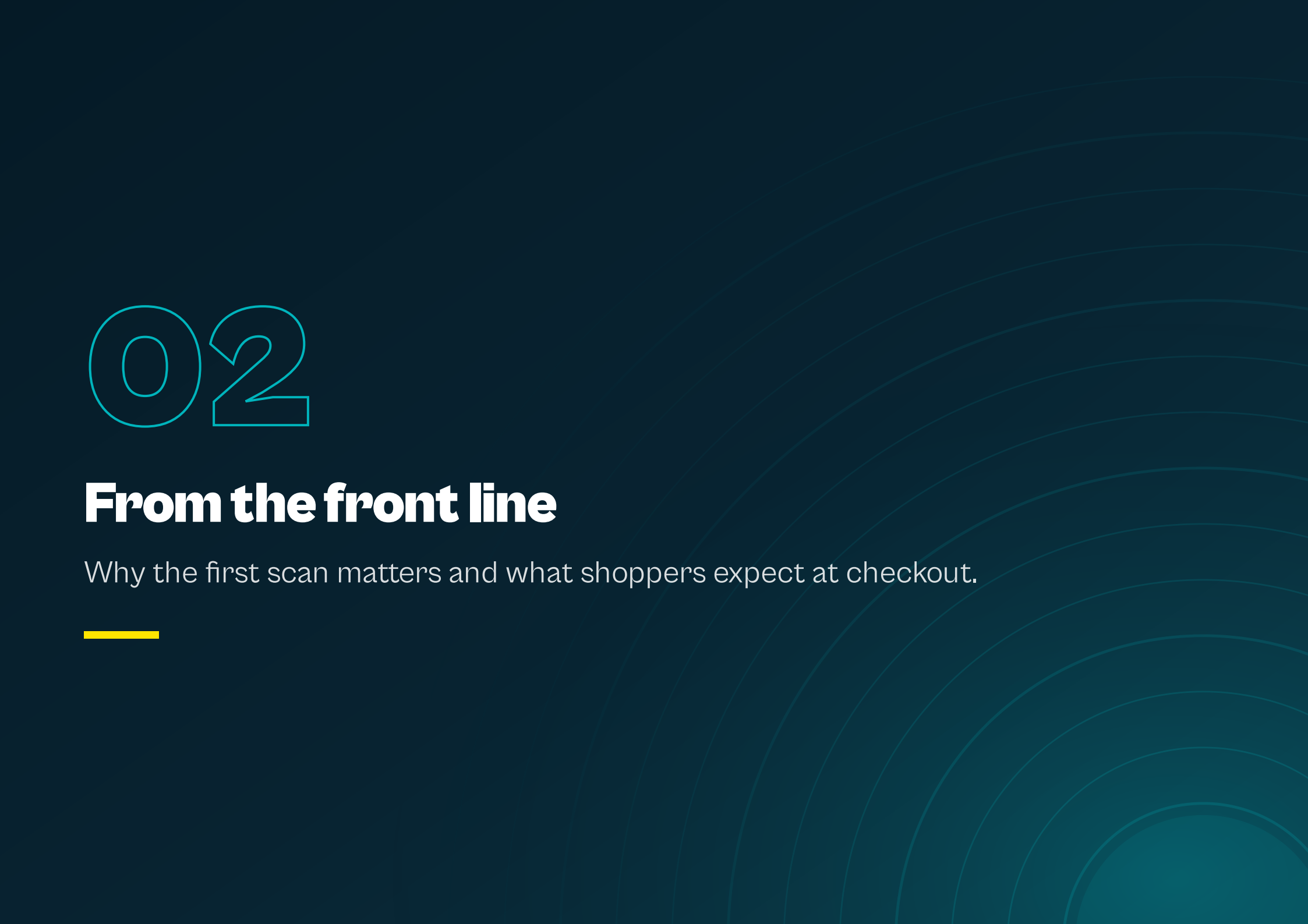
Returns in January's busiest week compared with December's busiest week

+13%

Outbound volume in the first full week of January compared with a normal September week

WHAT TO DO NOW

- 1 Plan returns staffing for **mid-January** rather than the week after Christmas.
- 2 Make sure your returns label and process are live on connexx before December.
- 3 Keep January staffing close to Peak levels because outbound volume bounces back straight away.



02

From the front line

Why the first scan matters and what shoppers expect at checkout.





"The first scan is crucial. As soon as the parcel is scanned, the data updates automatically. When there's no scan, the parcel hasn't reached the courier."

LOUISE POWELL
HEAD OF ACCOUNT MANAGEMENT,
ITD GLOBAL

THE FIRST SCAN

Missing scans were our most common Peak call

Until a courier scans your parcel your customer has no tracking to follow.

1

Label created

You print the label.
The courier knows
a parcel is coming.

2

Handed over

The parcel is
collected or
dropped off.

3

First scan

The courier scans
it. Tracking
updates
automatically.

4

On its way

Your customer
can track it to the
door.

WHAT TO DO NOW

1

Only create labels for parcels that are packed and ready to go.

2

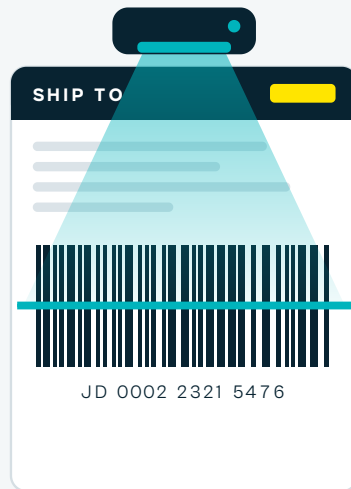
Book collections that match your Peak volume, especially on Mondays.

3

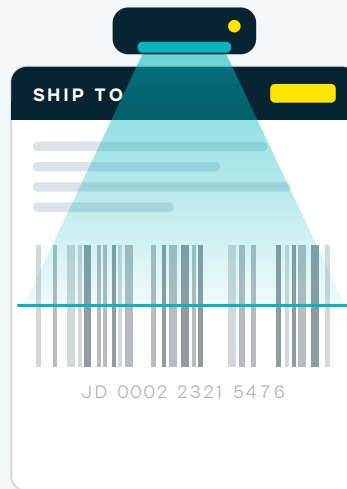
Check for **unscanned parcels** in connexx every day and raise them early through **Get Support**.

A label that won't scan won't track

If a courier can't read your barcode the parcel misses its first scan and your customer sees no tracking.



Scanned • tracking live



No read • no tracking

Faded print

Low ink leaves grey bars a scanner can't read.

Streaks and gaps

A dirty print head leaves white lines.

Shrunk to fit

A scaled-down label can be too small to read.

Creased or covered

Tape or folds across the barcode block the scan.

WHAT TO DO NOW

1

Test before Peak. Print a label on the printer you'll use on your busiest day and scan it.

2

Check the ink and print head. Replace them before they fade rather than in the middle of Peak.

3

Keep a spare printer and extra label stock, because Monday is the worst day to run out.

Delivery is part of what you sell

Shoppers judge you on delivery choice and reliability, and Peak is when both are tested hardest.

Shoppers want choice

5 vs 2.6

delivery options shoppers expect at checkout vs the average retailers offered in Peak 2025

Retail Economics & GFS, 2026

8 in 10

shoppers would leave a basket if their preferred delivery option wasn't offered

DHL eCommerce, 2025

Reliability is tested

29%

of retailers missed or only just met their delivery promise during Peak 2025

Retail Economics & GFS, 2026

37%

of people receiving parcels had a delivery problem in a single month

Citizens Advice, 2025

Missed promises lose trust

73%

of shoppers are unlikely to buy again after a missed delivery promise

Retail Economics & GFS, 2026

2 in 5

UK shoppers dropped an online purchase because of delivery in the past year

Sendcloud, 2025

WHAT TO DO NOW

- 1** Offer **more than 1 delivery option:** standard, next-day and out-of-home where you can.
- 2** Only promise what Peak can deliver. Add a day and show your cut-offs clearly.
- 3** Make your returns policy simple and visible **before** checkout.

Sources: Retail Economics & GFS, UK Delivery Benchmark 2026 (mystery shop of 100 retailers, Dec 2025, and 2,000 UK shoppers); DHL eCommerce, E-Commerce Trends Report 2025 (24,000 shoppers, 24 markets); Citizens Advice parcel research, Nov 2025 (8,000 UK adults); Sendcloud UK consumer survey, May 2025 (1,000 UK shoppers).

03

Your plan for Peak 2026

Your 10 actions and a week-by-week calendar to plan around the courier cut-offs.



10 actions for Peak 2026

Each action sits in the month you need to do it.

Plan

OCTOBER

01

Forecast early

Volume started climbing in late October last year.

02

Read the surcharge sheets

Check Peak charges and size rules.

03

Set up a second courier

Single-carrier shippers had 11% more undelivered parcels.

Prepare

NOVEMBER

04

Offer delivery choice

8 in 10 shoppers would leave without their preferred option.

05

Publish cut-offs and add a day

Transit times got longer during Peak.

06

Get returns ready

Returns peaked in mid-January.

Deliver

PEAK

07

Plan your international peak

Expect it in the week of the 7th of December.

08

Staff for Mondays

Peak Mondays averaged 2.4x a normal day.

09

Get the first scan right

Missing scans were our most common Peak call.

Every day

ALL PEAK

10

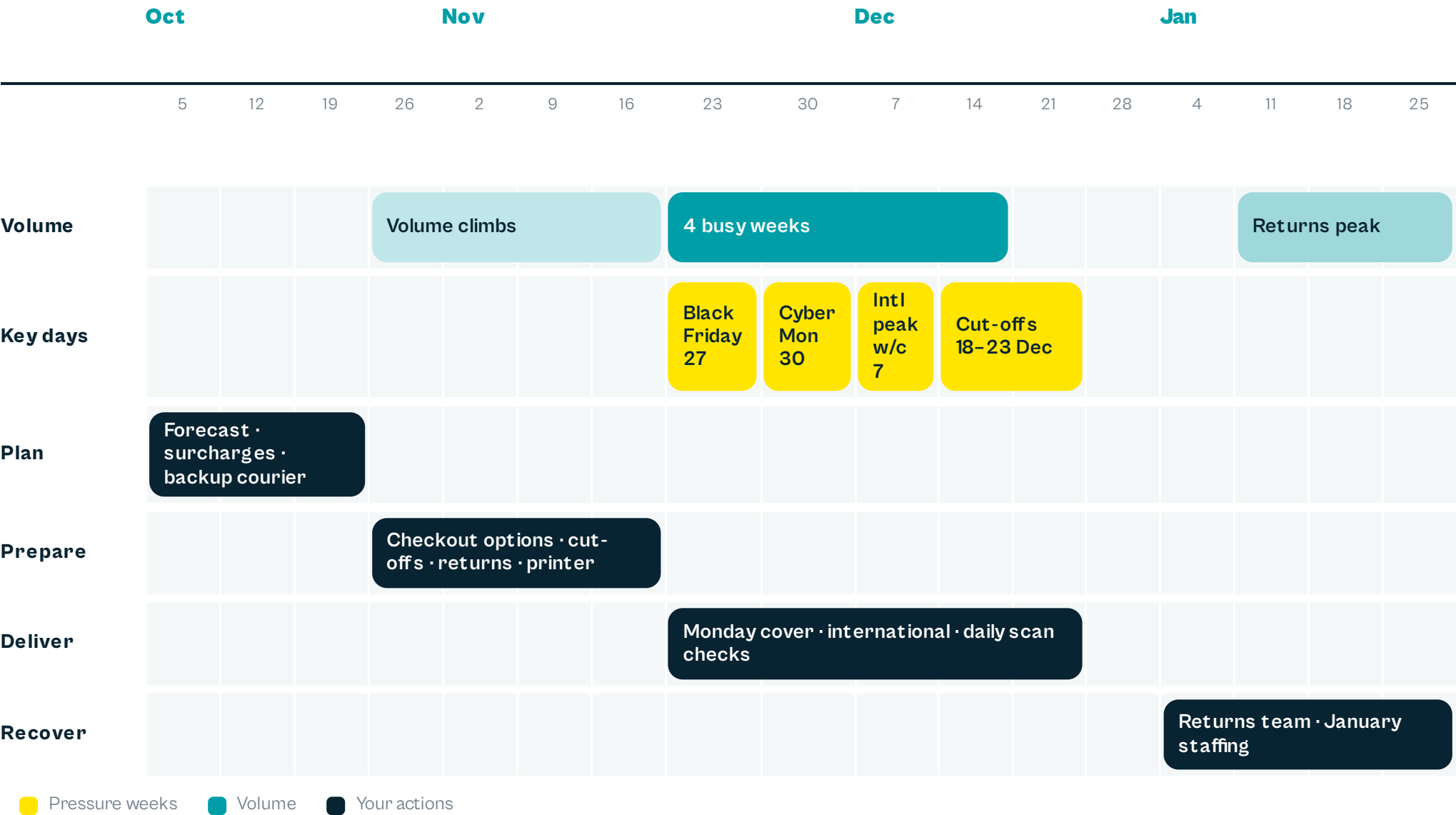
Check your label printer

Use a high-quality printer and check the ink before Peak.

Get these right and your parcels move from day one. Your customers will always know where their order is.

Your Peak 2026 at a glance

We have mapped last year's pattern onto this year's calendar, week by week.



COURIER CUT-OFFS

Last posting dates for Christmas 2026

Show these dates on your site now and leave a day of headroom before each one.

COURIER	ECONOMY / 48HR	NEXT-DAY / 24HR	GOOD TO KNOW
 Royal Mail	Sun 20 Dec Tracked 48	Tue 22 Dec Tracked 24	No collections on Christmas Day. Collections on 24 and 31 Dec must be back at the hub by 2pm.
 Evri	Sun 20 Dec Standard, by 23:59	Mon 21 Dec Next Day, by 23:59	Super Sundays on 29 Nov, 6 and 13 Dec. No deliveries on 25, 26 and 28 Dec or 1 Jan.
 InPost	Mon 21 Dec 48hr collections	Tue 22 Dec 24hr collections	Drop-offs at InPost points by Sat 19 Dec. Closed 25-27 Dec.
 DPD	—	Wed 23 Dec Last hub sort before Christmas	No hub sorts on 24, 25, 28 and 31 Dec or 1 Jan. No deliveries on 25, 26 and 28 Dec or 1 Jan.
 FedEx	—	Wed 23 Dec Domestic, delivered Thu 24 Dec	Regular collections cancelled on 24 Dec. No service on 25-26 Dec.

Dates are the couriers' published 2026 cut-offs for collection. Parcels collected after these dates are still delivered, but after Christmas.

Your Peak readiness checklist

Tick each box in the PDF as you go, or print the page for your team.

October

- ☐ Share your Peak forecast with ITD
- ☐ Read courier surcharge sheets and size rules
- ☐ Set up and test a second courier

November

- ☐ Publish cut-off dates on your site
- ☐ Offer more than 1 delivery option
- ☐ Add a day to delivery promises
- ☐ Book extra Monday collections
- ☐ Check your label printer and ink

Peak

- ☐ Plan international capacity for the 7th of December
- ☐ Only label parcels that are ready
- ☐ Check unscanned parcels in connexx daily
- ☐ Raise issues early through Get Support

January

- ☐ Staff up for mid-January returns
- ☐ Keep outbound staffing up

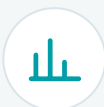


The engine
behind **17.5m**
labels a year

HOW WE SUPPORT YOU

We're with you through Peak

Intelligence



A live view of everything you ship, with the parcels that need attention surfaced before your customers chase you.

Multi-Carrier Dispatch



One place to dispatch across the carriers you ship with, in the label format and manifest each one needs.

Integrated Tracking



One tracking view across your carriers, with live status pulled straight from the source.

Store & Workflow Connectivity



Native integrations where it matters, an API for the rest.

Ready for Peak?

Talk to us about your Peak plan,
or use Get Support in connexx at any time.

[Contact us](#)



Smarter shipping for a simpler tomorrow

ITD Global has been a multi-carrier shipping platform since 2004, and through connexx businesses ship domestically and internationally with 16 couriers on one platform.

WAREHOUSING AND FULFILMENT

Delta Fulfilment

Delta Fulfilment provides order fulfilment for eCommerce businesses from its warehouse in Wrexham. It takes care of order processing so brands can focus on growth.

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SUPPORT

Get Support in connexx

connexx.co.uk

Web

itdglobal.com

Web

deltafulfilment.co.uk